FALL/WINTER EDITION *NOVEMBER/DECEMBER 2026*

CIRCUIT WRITER NEWSLETTER

BUILDING TRUST, STRENGTHENING COMMUNITY

THE MINISTRY OF COMMUNITY OUTREACH AND ENGAGEMENT

While in graduate school, I began serving the community in Dayton, Ohio, motivated to make a difference despite concerns about rejection and failure. I walked the neighborhood, listened to people in local barbershops, and joined pickup basketball games in the park. These conversations helped establish common ground and build trust.

Meaningful service starts with listening and building relationships. After graduation, I had the opportunity to serve in a community in West Philadelphia. Together, we developed summer camps, youth sports, after-school activities, and technology and exercise programs for older adults—all designed to address practical needs and foster connection. Serving in an urban setting presented challenges, but we made meaningful progress in addressing the community's needs.

In our current setting, we are exploring ways to coordinate our community outreach. Under Ms. Laurie Corbin's direction, the ministry will listen to neighbors, collaborate with local organizations, and support people facing hardship or isolation. She will work with our mission team and other groups to coordinate our efforts in this community and beyond. We cannot do everything, but we can do our part well and glorify God through collaboration.

Pastor Robert L. Johnson

GET INVOLVED

TO PARTICIPATE, CONTACT MS. CORBIN TO DISCUSS HOW YOUR TIME AND SKILLS CAN CONTRIBUTE TO THIS INITIATIVE. TOGETHER, WE CAN TRANSLATE OUR COMMITMENT INTO MEANINGFUL ACTION.

COMMUNITY OUTREACH AND ENGAGEMENT

As part of Community Outreach and Engagement (COE) Ministry, Messiah has begun connecting with community organizations and churches in Montgomery and Philadelphia counties. The COE ministry is part of Messiah's mission and vision to build relationships and share Christs' love through consistent community engagement. The new ministry is an expansion and establishes more formal connections related to several existing activities the church facilitates. These include the back-to-school backpack/book giveaway, Thanksgiving baskets, food pantry, Spring Festival and Family movie nights.

As part of the COE ministry, we are looking to have on-going partnerships with organizations, schools, neighborhood associations, and other churches. For example, as part of the bookbag giveaway we connected with a program that serves women in substance use treatment and their children in Philadelphia. We were able to provide twenty-five bookbags for these children. More recently, the COE ministry has convened meetings with Maternity Care Coalition to explore collaboration with their early childhood education program, based in Norristown. This program serves children ages to three years old and their families. Proposed activities to support the program include distribution of Thanksgiving baskets, a holiday luncheon/dinner for them at their site, adoption of families for holiday gift giving, and distribution of books and educational materials received by Messiah from the book drive and donations from church members.

Other collaborations have been initiated with the Montgomery County Office of Maternal and Child Health and the Tri-County YWCA. Both organizations create opportunities for sharing resources with church and community members and participation in Messiah's health and wellness events. Finally, the COE ministry has outreach to New Hope Baptist Church in Norristown to explore potential collaboration. During a site visit, Messiah representatives learned about New Hope's food pantry and distribution program. In turn, one of New Hope's ministers recently toured Messiah and discussed how the two churches could work together to meet the community's spiritual and material needs. We are excited about this new ministry and look forward to our continued expansion of collaborations in the community in the future.





A Year of God's Faithfulness

A Year-End Message from Pastor Johnson

Dear Messiah Church Family,

As we come to the close of another year, I am filled with gratitude for the faithfulness of God and for each of you. Through every season of joy, challenge, growth, and change—the Lord has remained steadfast. He has guided our steps, strengthened our fellowship, and reminded us that we never walk alone.

This year, we have worshipped together, prayed for one another, served our neighbors, and shared the hope of Christ. Every act of kindness, every willing hand, every prayer offered, and every gift faithfully given has helped advance the ministry of our church. Thank you for the many ways you have demonstrated love, generosity, and commitment.

We also remember those who have experienced loss, illness, disappointment, or hardship. May you know that your church family stands with you. More importantly, may you rest in the promise that God is near to the brokenhearted and faithful in every circumstance.

As we look toward the new year, let us move forward with renewed faith and expectation. God is still at work—in our homes, in our congregation, and throughout our community. May we remain rooted in His Word, devoted to prayer, united in love, and ready to serve wherever He leads.

My prayer is that the coming year will bring each of you a deeper awareness of God's presence, a stronger trust in His promises, and fresh opportunities to reflect the light of Christ. Let us enter it not with fear, but with hope, remembering that the One who has brought us this far will continue to lead us.

May the peace of Christ fill your hearts and homes throughout the holiday season and into the year ahead. Thank you for allowing me the privilege of serving as your pastor.

With gratitude and blessings,

Pastor Robert L. Johnson

Messiah UMC Women's Ministries

Connect, grow in faith, and serve through Messiah Church's women's ministries. Each group offers a welcoming place for fellowship and spiritual growth.

WHAM (Women Helping Around Messiah)

Build friendships through fellowship and service while supporting church ministries and projects. Enjoy movie nights, game nights, craft nights motivational speakers, and opportunities to serve the church community.
Coordinator: Mrs. Patty Rooney
Schedule: Watch for meeting and project announcements.

Women in the Word

Deepen faith through reading, Bible study, and thoughtful conversation. Discuss fiction and nonfiction books, grow in understanding of Christ, and explore connections between faith and daily life. Women at every stage of their faith journey are welcome.
Facilitator: Minister Kimberly Charleston
Schedule: Contact the facilitator and check church website for the current study schedule.

Women at the Well

Discover the stories of women in the Bible and explore how their experiences speak to life today. Build friendships through welcoming conversation, shared study, and reflection.
Facilitators: Minister Jennifer Crosby and Minister Brenda Roberson
Schedule: In person at the church on the second Saturday of each month at 10:00 AM.

Join Us

Explore one or more of these ministries! Contact the leaders listed above for details, or visit www.messiahmethodistchurch.com for church information and event announcements.

Women at the Well

Women at the Well is a women's ministry whose mission is to gather women into a Christ-centered sisterhood where every woman is welcomed, strengthened, and renewed through God's Word, shared faith, loving support, and the transforming power of Jesus Christ. Women at the Well meets on the second Saturday of each month. Ministers Jennifer Crosby and Brenda Roberson are the facilitators.

Our first gathering was Saturday, October 10, 2026. The topic discussed was the woman at the well in John 4:1-42. Our next meeting will be **Saturday, November 14, 2026**, at 10:00 am. Come out for the fellowship, fun, and Bible study. All are welcome and please bring a friend.

Min. Brenda Roberson



Sunday School

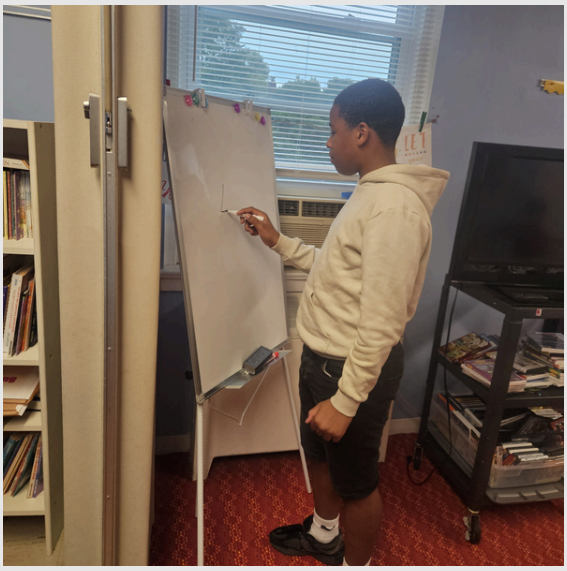
Our Sunday School students continue to deepen their understanding of how God works in their lives through the stories of biblical heroes and the examples of people they know today. This year's theme is "God Has Big Plans for You!" At the start of the school year, our class learned that God has a plan for each of us. Students then set personal goals for the Sunday School year related to school, family, sports, or other activities. We revisit these goals regularly to review their progress and remind the children to ask for God's help as they work toward them. We continue to reinforce each lesson with games and activities. Their favorites are Pictionary, Tattle, and "Who Do You Know Who This Is?" We also occasionally watch a movie to support class discussions or introduce topics not covered in our lessons.

We are proud of the presentation the children gave to Pastor J for Pastor Appreciation Day, when they expressed their love and gratitude for him. In the weeks ahead, we will learn about Joseph and his coat of many colors, and Daniel in the fiery furnace. We will also create fall and Christmas crafts, plan how to celebrate Jesus' birth with the congregation, and discuss ways to share God's love with other children in the community. We invite you and your children to join us on Sundays at 9:45 am. We would be delighted to see you.









A VIEW FROM THE HILL

A Report and Reflection from the Board of Trustees of Messiah United Methodist Church

Thank you to everyone helping us identify maintenance needs and find solutions. Your care and support help us maintain our church property and prevent future problems.

Repairs and Financial Impact

As our large church building ages, its maintenance needs grow. Reported repair costs exceed $80,000 this year, putting pressure on our finances. Most of these expenses are for the parsonage.

Gym Access and Security

As the weather changes and rentals increase, we are planning additional projects, including a new gym entry access panel to improve security. Work is expected to begin in the next couple of weeks, once parts are ordered and the contractor is ready, with completion anticipated within a few months. We'll keep you updated. Existing gym keys will be recalled when the system is ready, and Trustee Lafayette Charleston and church administrative assistant Mary Basmajian will help coordinate its use.

Church members will still be welcome to use the gym. Please request access through the church office so the trustees can coordinate schedules and arrange entry codes for designated groups.

Township Drainage Work

We are working with the township on drainage pipe replacement along Ridge Pike. The trustees' chair is finalizing agreements for a reported $17,000 buyout involving the front edge of our property, allowing payment to the church. The work is not expected to significantly change the property's frontage or affect the sign or lighting.

The project schedule and specific disruptions are not yet known. Temporary weekday office closures may be needed, but other normal operations are expected to continue. We'll share updates as details become available. Thank you for your patience as we coordinate with the township.

Facility Use and Cleaning

All voting on church property will move to the gym, where cleaning will be coordinated to keep the space ready for use. We welcome Mr. Norman Landis, who will provide midweek cleaning in the gym and other areas as needed. Our current cleaning contracts are still employed with Saga Church. No changes and currently cleaning companies and persons are anticipated at this time.

Ongoing Care and Member Support

The trustees are looking for ways to reduce costs, including doing more of the work ourselves, while keeping our property ready for worship and community activities.

If you notice a maintenance issue, please send a written description to the church office or a trustee. Thank you for helping care for our church. Please consider increasing your giving to support this ongoing work.



PARSONAGE WORK









The Ledger: The Report from the Treasurer Ho Chang

Repairs to the parsonage and church buildings have created significant financial challenges this year. The treasurer's report below outlines our current financial position.

2026 Member Giving Plans:

2026 Budgeted Amount: $176,500
Pro-Rata Budgeted Amount: $132,375
2026 Actual Amount Collected: $92,978

2026 Profit/Loss:

Total Income: $119,590
Total Expenses: $207,655
Net Income: -$88,065

Messiah is facing one of its most challenging financial periods in recent years.
The report shows a substantial net loss, largely attributable to unforeseen expenses related to the parsonage and church buildings.
Although property ownership requires ongoing maintenance, several repair needs have arisen within a short period this year, placing additional pressure on our finances.
We also continue to carry a negative balance associated with the furnace expenditure.

We are entering a period when Messiah members have historically demonstrated strong financial support. We hope that this tradition of generosity will continue.

HO

Township Funds and Congregational Support

On a positive note, the church expects to receive $17,000 in connection with the township's work at the front of the driveway. The congregation's continued financial support remains essential to sustaining the church's operations. Thank you for your generosity and commitment to Messiah.

Closing Prayer

Gracious God, thank You for the generosity and faithfulness of our congregation. Guide us to be wise stewards of all You have entrusted to us. Provide for the needs of our church, strengthen our unity, and help us give with willing hearts as we serve You and our neighbors. In Jesus' name, we pray. Amen.

Chicken BBQ

A net profit of $1,617.00 was made in chicken barbeque sales this year, $500.00 ahead of last year. Thank you to Pastor J, we made $651.00 in online sales versus $80.00 last year. On Sunday, we made $579.00 in sales of leftovers and donations. Thank you to Todd Oandasan who purchased the last 10 bags, which brought the net proceeds to $2,196.00. Thank you to everyone who supported us. - Mark Rooney

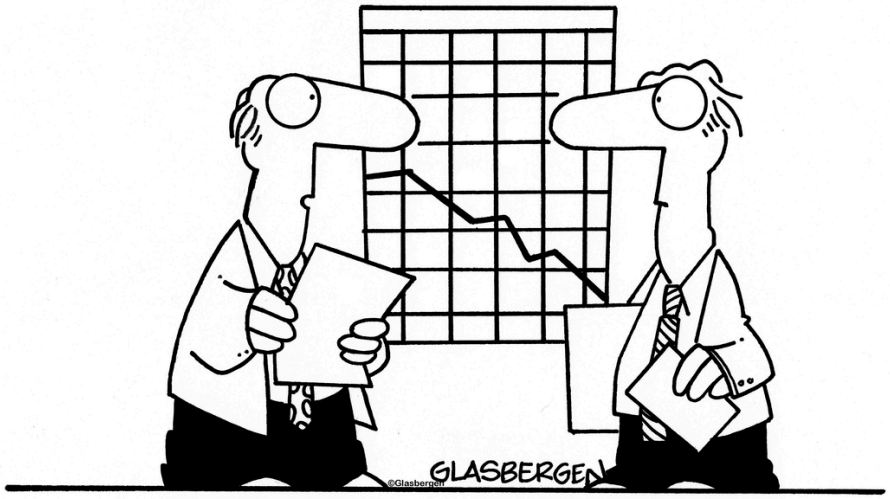












“How much would it cost to add God to our board of directors?”

Happy

BIRTHDAY ELSIE!



Messiah UM Church

Upcoming Events

November & December

Family Game Night
Friday, November 13 · 6:00 PM

Friendsgiving Brunch
Sunday, November 22 · 12:00 PM

Youth Sweet Shop
Sunday, December 20 · 12:00 PM

Christmas Concert
Sunday, December 20 · 5:00 PM

Christmas Eve Services
Family Service · 6:00 PM
Candlelight & Communion · 10:00 PM

527 Ridge Pike, Lafayette Hill, PA 19444

Phone: 610-828-0118; Fax: 610-828-2463
Church office hours: Monday–Friday, 8am–11:30 am
Church email: messiahchurch@verizon.net

Pastor email: revrlj1@msn.com
Pastor Johnson's office hours: Monday–Thursday, 9 am–1 pm (mtg. by appt.)
Website: www.messiahmethodistchurch.com

Pastor: Rev. Robert L. Johnson
Minister of Music: Ransford Addae
Worship Leader: Kristen Moser
Admin. Assistant: Mary Basmajian
Sexton: John Basmajian

If you have an article or announcement about yourself, your family, or church activity for a future issue of the *Circuit Writer,* please submit it to the church office via email, mail, or hard copy in bin on door of office no later than the **15th** of the month. If there is a change of address, phone, or email, please submit updated contact information to the office via email or phoen.

Mission Statement: To win people to Christ, train believers to become disciples, and send disciples to impact the world.
Vision Statement: A place where faith and real life connect.

Our mission and vision statements serve as the foundation for all ministries and guide every decision, program, and interaction within Messiah UMC.

Messiah United Methodist Church
527 Ridge Pike
Lafayette Hill, PA 19444

Place
Stamp
Here

Sent with a prayer to: